

Major Scale Fingerings

3

Above is one octave of the c major scale played on a single string. Playing the major scale on a single string allows us to clearly see the interval pattern of the major scale- W W 1/2 W W W 1/2. On the guitar, a whole step is the distance of two frets and a half step is one fret. Try playing this series of intervals starting from any fret on any string and you'll hear that you have played the major scale transposed to different keys. Now compare the single string fingering with the first position fingering below:

3

If you play both of these fingerings, you'll notice that the sound is the same even though the two fingerings look quite different. When a scale or melody is played in position (across the strings) on guitar, the visual pattern does not reflect the intervallic pattern or the sound as clearly as if the scale was played on a single string. This is something which is important to keep in mind when practicing; It's easy to fall into thinking of scale fingerings merely as geometric patterns. We always want to strive to connect the sound with the visual aspect of playing the instrument. Here is the entire first position of the C major scale:

5 I. Form 1

Below are 5 more positions for this scale. Memorize all of these fingerings by playing them slowly and steadily saying or singing the note names and the scale degree numbers out loud as you go. This will be an important first step towards understanding the fingerboard. Remember, when playing in position, each finger is assigned to a fret. The number of the position indicates the fret at which the first finger is placed. Notes above or below this four-fret range should be played by stretching with the 4th (pinky) or 1st (index) fingers, respectively.

Using a set of blank chord frames, notate each of these fingerings. Mark the tonic notes (C) by putting a box around it. Indicate each stretch with (s). Once you know these scale fingerings for C major, learning other keys is easy; simply shift the fingerings to different frets just as you would a chord voicing.

14 II. Form 2

(s) (s)

TAB

3-5 2-3 5 2-4-5 3-5 1-3 5-3-1 5 3 5-4-2 5-3-2 5 3-2 5-3 5 2-3

22 V. Form 3

(s) (s)

TAB

8 5-7-8 5-7-9 5 7 5-6-8 5-7-8-7 5 8-6-5 7-5 9-7 5 8-7-5 8-7-5-7 8

31 VII. Form 4

TAB

8-10 7-8 10 7-9-10 7-9-10 8 10 7-8-10 8-7 10-8 10-9-7 10 9-7 10-8 7 10-8-7 8

IX. Form 5: Begins with a stretch

40 (s) (s) (s) (s) (s) (s)

TAB

8-10-12 8 10-12 9-10 12 10-12 8-10 12-10-8 12-10 12-10-9 12-10-9 12 10-8 12-10 8

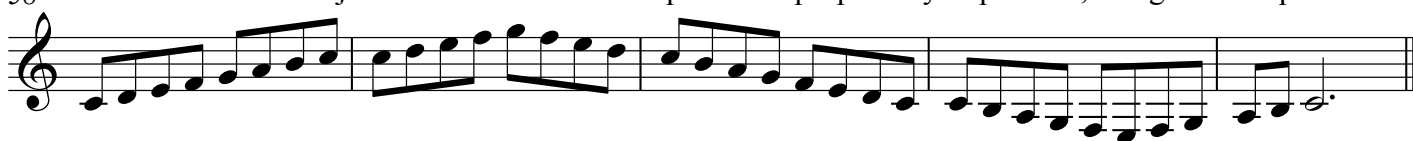
Form 1: same as 1st pos, but with no open strings

49 XII.

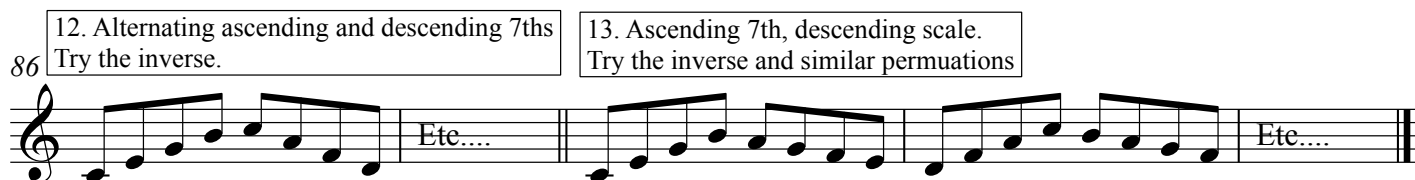
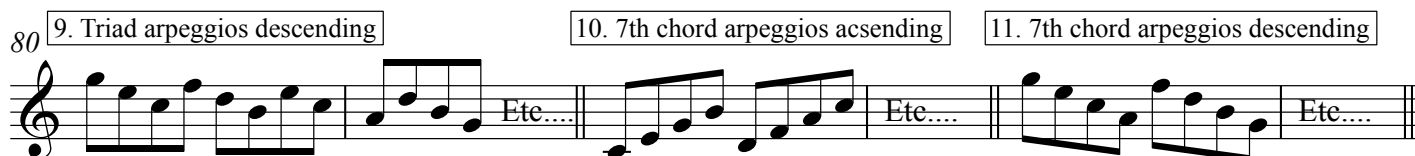
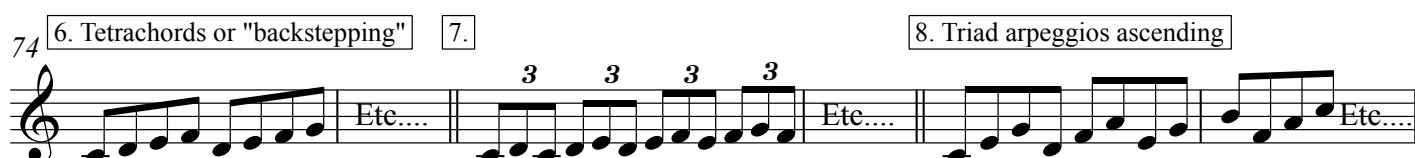
TAB

15 12-14-15 12-14 12-13 15 12-13-15 13-12 15-13 12 14-12 15 14-12 15-14 12 15-13-12 13-15 12-14 15

When practicing the C major scale, it helps to begin each octave on a strong beat, preferably, the first beat of the measure. This will help to emphasize the note C as the tonic, or "home base" note of the scale. We will see later that this sequence of notes can begin on any pitch, allowing us to play 7 "modes" of the major scale. Here is an example of the proper way to practice, using the first position:



Practice each of the positions of the C major scale with the following scale patterns. Remember to always begin and end with the tonic. Always use alternate picking—down, up with a pick or in with fingers.



Once you have a good understanding of the major scales in different positions on the fingerboard, learning fingerings for other modes is relatively easy. For every fingering of the major scale in a particular key that you learn, remember that you have learned a fingering for the seven "church modes" that are derived from that major scale; With the same fingering you use to play the C major scale in second position, for example, you can play the G mixolydian scale (5th mode of the major) simply by beginning and ending on the note G. These major scale fingerings are also a good starting point for learning other scales, such as the melodic minor or harmonic minor scales and the modes derived from them. In this case, you simply need to know which scale degrees differ from the parallel major scale. Again, beginning with the C major scale in second position, simply play E flats instead of E naturals to play C melodic minor.